

International Computer Science Competition

Pre-Final Round Information



Participants who successfully clear the Qualification Round are invited to the Pre-Final Round: a supervised 60-minute online exam with three problems. In this document you can find details about the following:

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1 Problems and Points

The Pre-Final Round consists of three problems varying in difficulty and points:

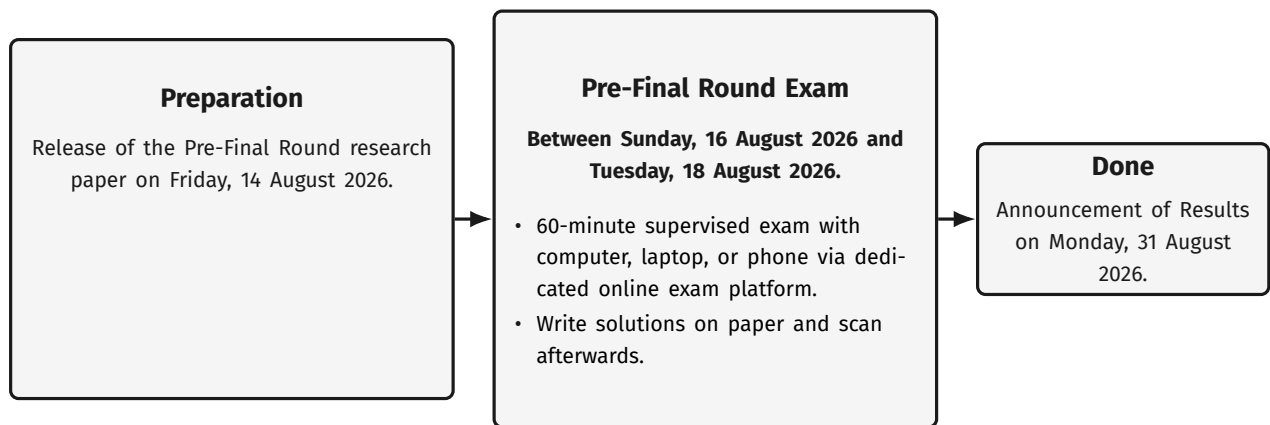
- **Problem A – Conceptual Problem (6 points):** Building on core concepts from the Qualification Round, potentially involving algorithm analysis or design.
- **Problem B – Coding Problem (6 points):** Tackling a more complex scenario requiring implementation, possibly related to optimization, data structures, or algorithmic design.
- **Problem C – Research Problem (8 points):** Requiring engagement with a contemporary research paper in CS (e.g., in ML, NLP, algorithms, or theoretical CS) to understand concepts and answer related questions.

The maximum score is 20 points. To qualify for the Final Round, participants must score at least 11/13/15 points (Junior/Youth/Senior). Clearly explaining your reasoning and approach is essential for all problems and significantly affects your score.

All problems are shown on a single page, and you may answer them in any order. You can move back and forth between problems at any time.

You write your solutions to the conceptual and research problems on paper. The coding problem is solved using the online code editor in the exam interface (Python, Java, C, or C++), using only standard libraries. Explain your approach in code comments; this way you can still receive partial points if your code does not run correctly.

2 Pre-Final Round Process



Phase 1: Preparation

This year's Pre-Final Round will begin on **Friday, 14 August 2026**, with the release of the research paper you are expected to read and familiarise yourself with. All participants who are qualified and registered (see Section 3) for the Pre-Final Round will receive the research paper via e-mail and via their participant account on that day. The paper is in English, but you may use translation tools and AI to help you comprehend the material before the exam.

Phase 2: Pre-Final Round Exam

You then have from **Sunday, 16 August 2026**, 00:01 UTC+0, until **Tuesday, 18 August 2026**, 23:59 UTC+0, to take the 60-minute exam at any point during this period using a computer, laptop, or phone. The exam must be supervised by a teacher (recommended) or, if no teacher is available, by ICSC using our online supervision system (see Section 4).

To take the Pre-Final Round Exam, you will log in to the dedicated exam platform: <https://icscompetition.org/exam>. Use your regular ICSC account details to sign in. After a few setup steps, you can start the exam. The Pre-Final Round problems will then appear on your screen. They are not available before this moment or during the preparation phase.

From the moment you start, you have 60 minutes to work on all problems. All problems are shown on one page, and you may answer them in any order.

You can bring blank sheets of paper (not more than twenty) and pens (not more than three) to take notes and to write down your solutions. Please use a new sheet of paper for each problem, write the problem number at the top of every page, and use multiple pages for a problem if needed. You are not allowed to bring your own copy of the research paper into the exam. However, the research paper will be available to you directly in the exam interface.

Phase 3: Answer Scan

After the exam finishes, you will have 10 minutes to upload clear scans of your written solutions using your phone. This step is still supervised, and you are not allowed to work on the problems anymore. You will scan a QR code shown on the exam screen, which will take you to the upload interface. If you use your phone to take the exam, you will need a second

phone for scanning and uploading. For this reason, we strongly recommend using a laptop or computer for the exam itself.

Phase 4: Exam Completion

After you have uploaded your written solutions, you are done.

The results of the Pre-Final Round will be announced on **Monday, 31 August 2026.**

3 Registration Details

If you succeed in the Qualification Round, you can choose to participate in the Pre-Final Round by registering from your participant account.

The registration deadline for the Pre-Final Round is **Tuesday, 11 August 2026**.

This educational opportunity comes with diverse costs, including those for human resources, technical infrastructure, materials and more. While our sponsors cover some of these expenses, we need to ask participants to cover this year's Pre-Final Round registration costs of 15 EUR to make ICSC on an international level possible. There are no other costs for participants throughout this year's competition.

The registration costs are necessary to provide the resources required to run a competition at this scale. This includes the costs for human resources and submission evaluations, particularly of the comprehensive Pre-Final Round, amongst other expenses. You can find detailed information on how the registration costs are used in our information flyer: [Registration Costs Flyer 2026](#)

To register for the Pre-Final Round, please log into your participant account.

Financial Aid Program

Like every year, we offer a limited number of cost waivers and reductions for those participants facing financial hardship, to allow as many students as possible to participate in this year's Pre-Final Round:

- **50% Cost Reductions:** A 50% reduction of the registration costs (7.50 EUR).
- **Full Waivers:** A limited number of complete cost waivers.

The Financial Aid Request Form is accessible to all Qualification Round participants who have qualified for the Pre-Final Round. It asks for a description of your financial situation and allows an optional appendix. Requests are reviewed based on demonstrated need, and participants with strong Qualification Round submissions are given priority.

The application deadline is Friday, 24 July 2026, and all applicants are notified about the outcome by Monday, 3 August 2026. For more information, please visit: <https://icscompetition.org/financialaid>

4 Supervision Details

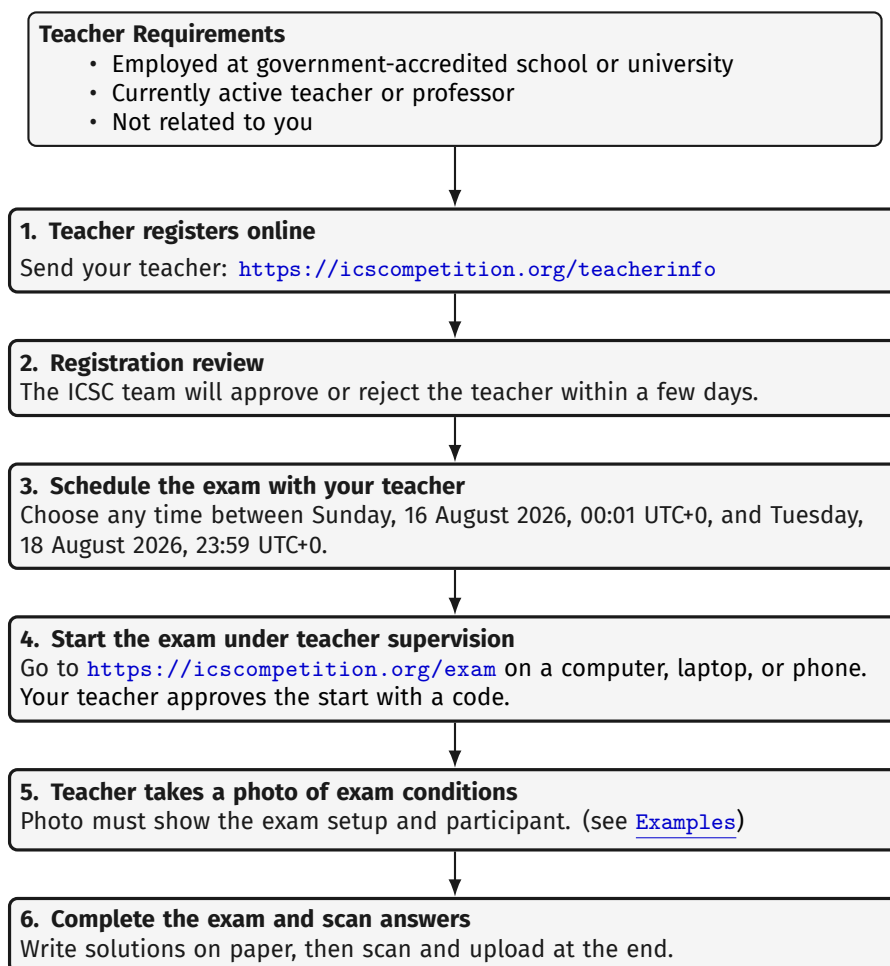
The 60-minute exam must be supervised either

- (Option A) by a teacher or
- (Option B) by ICSC using an online supervision system.

Teacher supervision is the preferred option, as the online supervision system requires a comprehensive setup. If no teacher is available, you may choose the online supervision option instead.

4.1 Option A: Supervision with Teacher (recommended)

This figure summarizes the steps described on the next page:



Please ask a teacher who meets the following criteria to supervise your Pre-Final Round Exam:

- Must be employed at a government-accredited school or university (i.e., no private tutors).
- Must currently be an active teacher or professor (i.e., no retired teachers).
- Must not be related to you (i.e., no family members).

A single teacher may supervise the exam of multiple participants at the same time. This is required if there are other Pre-Final Round participants from your school. The teacher only needs to upload a single photo, regardless of how many participants they supervise. Next:

1. Your teacher must register online.
(Send your teacher this link for details: <https://icscompetition.org/teacherinfo>)
2. We will review the registration and approve or reject the teacher within a few days.
3. After approval, the teacher adds you as a student via their teacher account and may supervise your exam at any suitable time between Sunday, 16 August 2026, 00:01 UTC+0, and Tuesday, 18 August 2026, 23:59 UTC+0.
4. Under teacher supervision, you can start the exam on a computer, laptop, or phone by opening the official exam platform: <https://icscompetition.org/exam>. To start, your teacher logs into their account and approves your exam by entering the approval code shown on your screen.
5. During the exam, your teacher must take a photo of the exam conditions (see [Examples](#)).

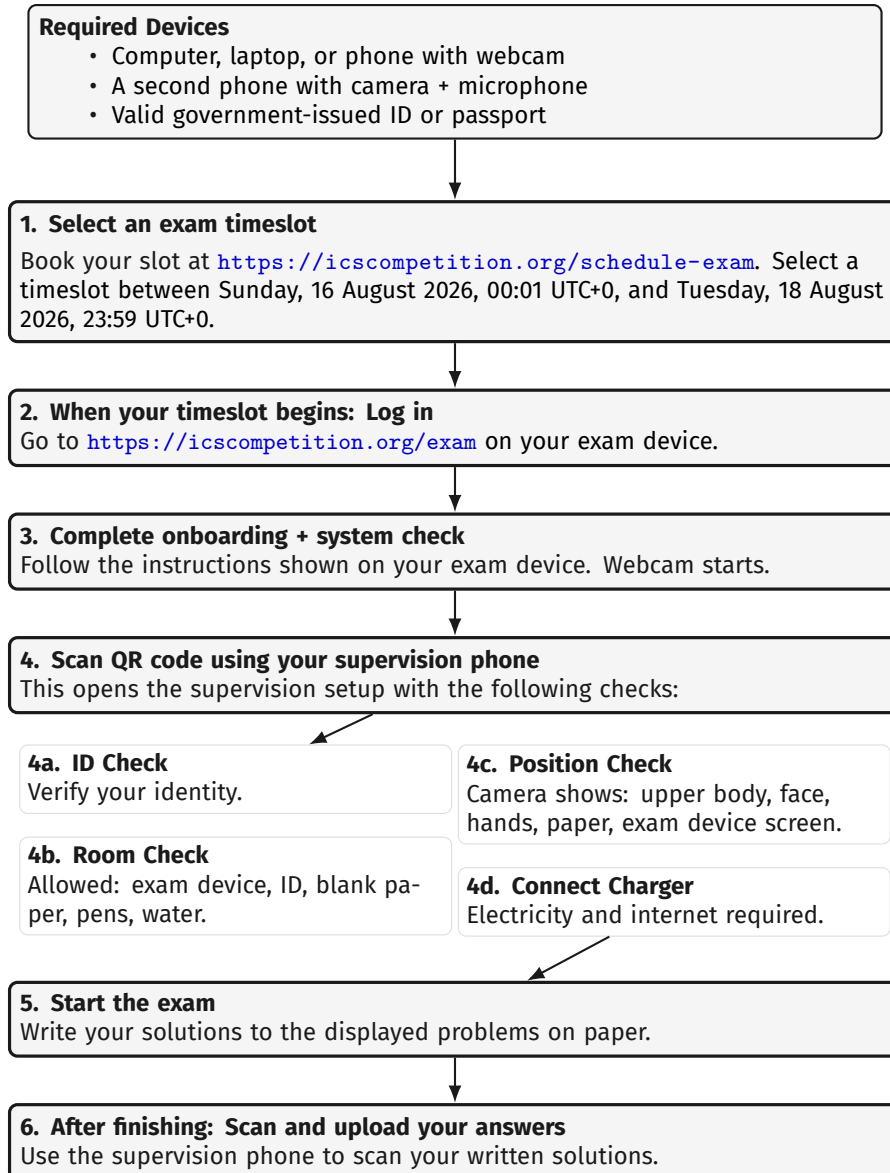
Participants may use either a school computer or a personal device to open the exam platform. The teacher must ensure that the participant does not cheat, use external help, or open other windows during the exam. The following actions are considered cheating:

- Using other electronic devices (e.g., phones, calculators, AI tools).
- Using any external information source (e.g., internet, notes, books, your own copy of the research paper).
- Opening additional browser tabs, websites, or computer windows.
- Receiving help from the teacher or any other person.
- Exceeding the exam time limit.

In addition to supervision, we use automated methods to detect cheating, time violations, or unauthorized tool usage. Cheating will result in immediate disqualification.

4.2 Option B: Supervision without Teacher

If you do not have a teacher who can supervise your exam, you can still participate using the online supervision system. This figure summarizes the steps described on the next page:



To take the exam using the online supervision system, you will need:

- A computer, laptop, or phone with a webcam. (*exam device*)
- A phone with a working camera and microphone. (*supervision phone*)
- A valid government-issued ID card or passport.

All devices must be connected to the internet. If you use a phone as your exam device (i.e., to open the exam platform), you will need a second phone to supervise the exam.

Follow these steps to take the Pre-Final Round Exam:

1. Select an exam timeslot located between Sunday, 16 August 2026, 00:01 UTC+0, and Tuesday, 18 August 2026, 23:59 UTC+0, prior to your exam.

How?: Book your timeslot at <https://icscompetition.org/schedule-exam>. All Pre-Final Round participants will also receive a link via email and through their participant account together with the material released on Friday, 14 August 2026. Timeslots are available every 60 minutes. There is no deadline for selecting a timeslot; however, each timeslot can accommodate a maximum of 50 participants. Timeslots are assigned on a first-come, first-served basis, so we recommend choosing your slot early. You can change your selection as long as you have not started the exam.

2. When it is your scheduled time, log into the exam platform on your exam device using your ICSC participant account details: <https://icscompetition.org/exam>
3. Follow the onboarding and system check steps on your exam device. During these steps you will also start your webcam supervision via the interface.
4. After completing the system check, scan the QR code shown on your exam device to set up the supervision system on your phone. Follow the instructions, which include:
 - (a) Conducting an ID and face check to verify your identity.
 - (b) Conducting a room check to verify the exam environment.
(see below for **Requirements for the Exam Environment**)
 - (c) Conducting a position check to verify correct placement of the supervision phone.
(see below for **Requirements for the Supervision Phone Position**)
 - (d) Connect your supervision phone to a charging cable.

Notes: Please note that the supervision device requires a stable internet connection. It is the participant's responsibility to ensure a working internet connection throughout the entire exam.

5. Once the supervision setup is completed, you will be able to start the exam.
6. After finishing the exam, you will use your supervision phone to scan your answers.

Requirements for the Exam Environment:

- Only your exam device, your ID card, blank sheets of paper, pens, and something to drink are allowed.
- The room must be closed with the door shut.
- No notes, posters, or other materials may be in your field of view.
- No additional phones, monitors, calculators, or electronic devices may be present.
- No other person may be in the room.
- No noisy environments.
- No headphones.

You are not allowed to leave the exam environment at any time during the exam or before your answers have been scanned and uploaded. Using the restroom is not permitted once the exam has started.

Requirements for the Supervision Phone Position:

The phone must be placed to your left or right side, slightly behind you, at an angle that allows the camera to clearly capture:

1. Your upper body and partial face.
2. Your hands and the sheets of paper in front of you.
3. The screen of your exam device.

You can find examples of acceptable angles here: [Examples](#). We recommend preparing and testing your exam setup beforehand. You may use stable materials or stands to position your phone at an acceptable angle.

Data Privacy Notice: The data collected during the exam process is used exclusively for exam supervision and will be deleted shortly after the exam data has been evaluated and checked for any irregularities.

5 Preparation and Support

While extensive preparation is usually not required, strengthening your overall computer science knowledge and problem-solving skills is beneficial. Here are some tips:

- **Review Core Domains:**

Familiarize yourself with the typical domains of the Pre-Final Round, such as algorithms and data structures, computational complexity, algorithm design and analysis, optimization, and computational thinking.

- **Prepare for the Research Paper:**

Problem C involves a contemporary research paper. Practice reading and summarizing scientific texts to extract relevant claims, assumptions, and evidence. Read the paper carefully after it is released on Friday, 14 August 2026 — you may use translation tools and AI to help you understand it before the exam.

- **Practice Coding:**

Problem B is solved in the browser-based code editor using only standard libraries. Practice writing correct programs in Python, Java, C, or C++ without autocomplete or a debugger.

- **Review Qualification Round Problems:**

The conceptual problem builds on core concepts from the Qualification Round. Revisiting your earlier problems will help reinforce important concepts.

- **Explain Your Reasoning:**

Clearly explaining your reasoning and approach is essential for all problems and significantly affects your score. Practice writing structured, legible solutions on paper.

There is a comprehensive FAQ regarding the Pre-Final Round on our website which clarifies many questions and issues of participants: <https://icscompetition.org/support>

Our ICSC team is here to support you! If you have any questions or need support, feel free to reach out at info@icscompetition.org.

Questions and Answers

Do I need a teacher to take the exam?

No. A teacher is recommended, but if none is available you can be supervised by ICSC through our online supervision system. In that case you must book a timeslot at <https://icscompetition.org/schedule-exam> and have a second phone available.

Can I take the exam at any time during the window?

If a teacher supervises you, yes: any time between Sunday, 16 August 2026 and Tuesday, 18 August 2026. If you use the online supervision system, you must take the exam in the timeslot you booked.

Can my teacher supervise several students at once?

Yes. One teacher may supervise multiple participants at the same time and only needs to upload a single photo of the exam conditions.

What is the approval code?

If a teacher supervises you, your screen shows an approval code when you open the exam. Your teacher logs into their account and enters this code to start your exam.

May I bring the research paper into the exam?

No. The paper is available inside the exam interface during the whole exam. Bringing your own copy counts as using an unauthorized source of information.

Which programming languages can I use?

Python, Java, C, and C++, using only standard libraries. No external libraries or packages are allowed.

How do I hand in my handwritten solutions?

After the exam ends you have 10 minutes to scan and upload them, either by scanning a QR code with your phone (teacher supervision) or by following the instructions on your supervising phone (online supervision). This step is still supervised.

Can I participate only in the Qualification Round and skip the Pre-Final Round?

Yes, you may participate in the Qualification Round, receive your participation certificate, and choose not to continue. However, only those who join the Pre-Final Round can advance to further stages.

I had technical issues. Can I retake the exam?

No. Ensure a reliable internet connection and a working setup beforehand. It is not possible to pause, restart, or retake the exam after starting. If a genuine technical fault occurs, document it and contact us immediately at info@icscompetition.org.

What if I cannot afford the registration costs?

Apply for financial aid by Friday, 24 July 2026 at <https://icscompetition.org/financialaid>. Both 50% reductions and full waivers are available.